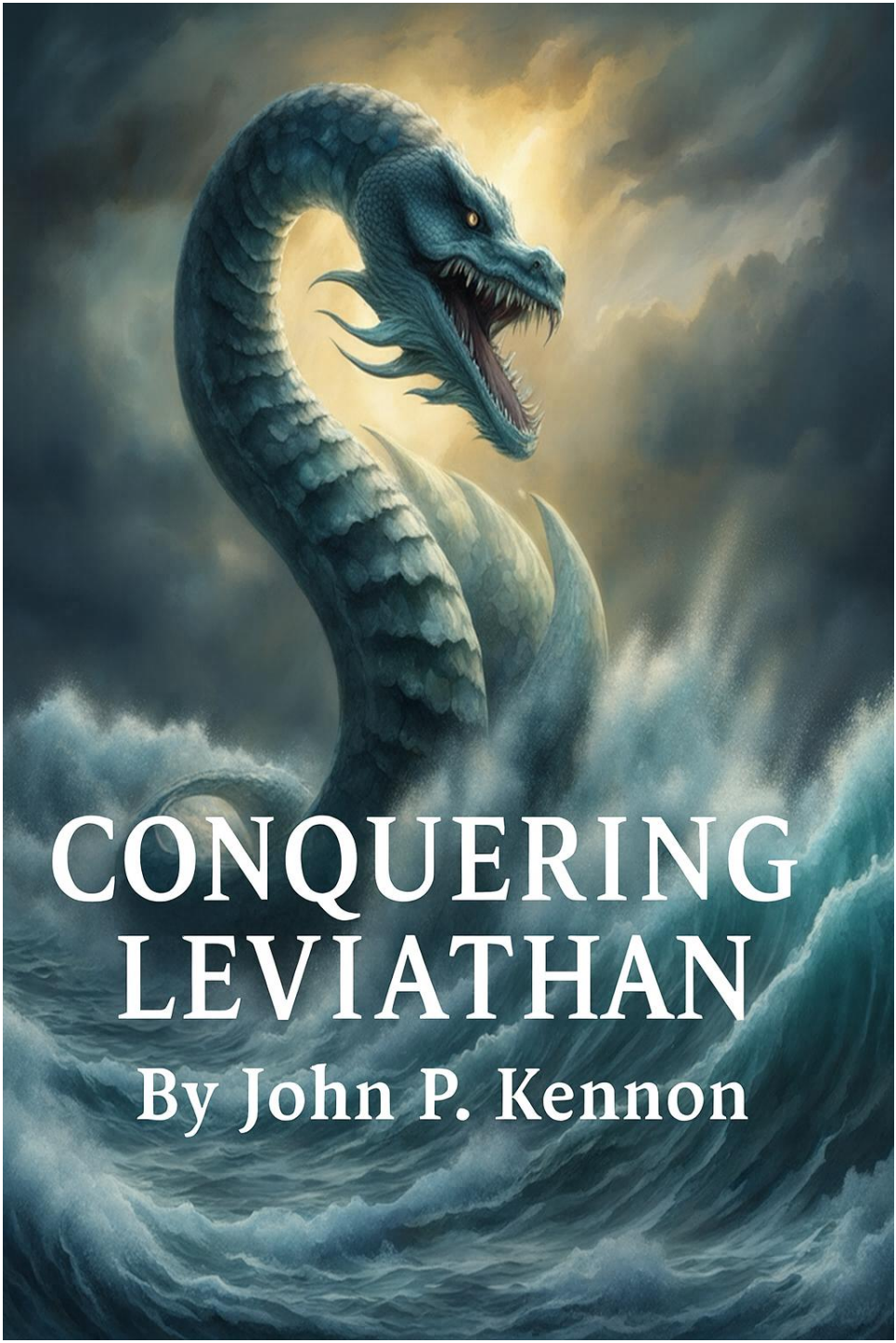

CONQUERING
LEVIATHAN
By John P. Kennon

CONQUERING LEVIATHAN

A Timeless Story of Faithfulness, Surrender, and the Life That Follows

John P. Kennon

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Any resemblance to real persons, living or dead, is intentional only insofar as truth reflects the human condition.

Printed in the United States of America.

First Edition

Author's Note

Why This Work Was Written

This work was born out of a long and often painful realization—one formed slowly, over years of ministry, observation, and love for the Church.

Within Christianity, a strain of fear-based faith has quietly taken root. It emphasizes obedience without intimacy, discipline without dependence, and righteousness without relationship. In these environments, faith is measured primarily by conformity, compliance, and control. The fruit of such faith is not holiness, but hardness. Not freedom, but fear.

I have watched churches grow cold where warmth once lived. I have seen faith reduced to checklists of do's and don'ts, where lives are weighed, measured, and often discarded when they fail to conform. I have seen authority assumed rather than entrusted, and man-made rules elevated to the level of divine mandate—where heaven is promised for compliance and hell is implied for deviation.

Over the course of more than thirty years, I have watched the fruit of this system mature—not into spiritual depth, but into fragmentation. Families wounded. Churches divided. Believers driven into strange and damaging doctrines—not because they were rebellious, but because fear eventually seeks refuge wherever it promises relief. I have seen sincere people become hardened, harsh, and deeply wounded—so conditioned by the terror of "getting it wrong" that grace itself begins to feel dangerous.

Fear-based faith does not produce devotion.
It produces survival.

And survival, when mistaken for faith, slowly starves the soul.

This is not a rejection of obedience. Scripture esteems obedience deeply. Nor is this a dismissal of discipline, holiness, or reverence. The problem is not structure itself, but **source**. Fruit does not fail because branches lack effort—it fails because roots lack life.

Bad fruit always reveals a problem in the root system.
Good fruit always grows from healthy roots.

The same tree can produce both—depending on the environment in which it is planted.

Grace-based faith does not remove obedience; it restores obedience to its proper place. It positions believers not to perform righteousness, but to **receive life**. It cultivates relationship with God, His Word, His Spirit, His people—so that obedience flows naturally as fruit rather than being forced by fear.

This book was not written to attack the Church.
It was written because I love her.

I believe the Spirit of God still desires to move freely among His people—not through fear, but through faith that abides; not through control, but through surrender; not through righteousness that stands alone, but through grace that gives life. I believe much of what has been lost was not stolen by rebellion, but surrendered to self-protection. And I believe what has been lost can be restored—not by striving harder, but by returning nearer.

What follows is not an argument, but a story. It is not written to shame the faithful, but to invite the weary. It is not meant to dismantle obedience, but to rescue it from isolation. The struggle described here is not rare—it is common to sincere

believers who have learned how to stand without learning how to lean.

At its heart, this book asks a question Scripture itself asks repeatedly, in many voices and many lives: whether faith will be something we manage, or something we receive. Whether obedience will be our proof, or our response. Whether righteousness will become our refuge—or whether God Himself will be.

It is possible to do everything right and still lose nearness.
It is possible to obey faithfully and still drift quietly.
And it is possible—by grace—to return.

There is one Lord, one faith, and one God—present, active, and sufficient.

He has never asked us to replace His work with our own.

Only to stop striving where He intends to supply.

Faith does not flourish when we try harder.

It flourishes when we finally let Him work.

Some of you have never experienced Jesus without condemnation.
You've known obedience.
You've known discipline.
You've known effort.

But the fellowship and liberty that comes
when accusation is gone
and grace is the source—
it is life-changing in the most profound way.

Once you taste it,
you don’t want the world anymore.
And you never want to live without Him again.

Freedom from condemnation doesn’t make you careless—
it makes you inseparable from the Lord

You weren’t created to survive Christianity.
You were created to **fellowship with Christ**.

And where the Spirit of the Lord is—
there is liberty.

This is not theory.

This is **inheritance**.
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Introduction

Why This Story Had to Be Told

This book was born out of a single, unsettling truth:

It is possible to be obedient to God and still be far from Him.

Scripture does not shy away from this reality. From the opening chapters of Genesis to the final words of Jesus, the greatest danger facing humanity has never been blatant rebellion, but **righteousness practiced apart from relationship**. The most devastating falls in Scripture are not moral collapses, but **relational separations**—moments when faith quietly gives way to self-sufficiency.

Adam and Eve did not fall because they sought evil. They fell because they were tricked into *independence*. They were not trying to overthrow God; they were deceived into believing they could become like Him—knowing how to live rightly—without remaining dependent on Him. The fracture of Eden was not primarily moral. It was relational.

That same deception echoes throughout Scripture.

Job was upright, blameless, and faithful—yet God still confronted him. Not for sin, but for presumption. Job's repentance was not over wrongdoing, but over standing in a place that belonged to God alone. Paul was zealous beyond his peers, perfectly aligned with the law, yet his righteousness had to be dismantled before grace could live within him. The rich young ruler had kept every commandment, but when Jesus invited him into true faith—faith that required surrender rather than achievement—he walked away sorrowful, unable to let go of control.

Even those who performed miracles in Jesus' name were rejected, not because of what they did, but because of what they lacked: relationship.

"I never knew you."

These stories reveal a sobering truth:

Anything done apart from faith—even obedience—can become sin.

Scripture declares, *"Whatsoever is not of faith is sin."* This is not merely a moral statement; it is a relational one. Actions not rooted in faith, dependence, and abiding can become self-sustaining systems of righteousness—impressive, disciplined, and ultimately empty.

This book explores that truth through story rather than argument.

Conquering Leviathan is not a critique of obedience, discipline, or righteousness. These are gifts. But when they are severed from faith, they quietly become substitutes for God Himself. The Leviathan named in this story is not wickedness in its obvious forms. It is **pride disguised as faithfulness**, **control mistaken for obedience**, **fear dressed as righteousness**.

The story that follows invites the reader to confront a question Scripture asks again and again:

Will faith be something you perform, or something you receive?

This is not a book about falling away. It is a book about letting go. And in that letting go, discovering life and life more abundantly.

Robes Without Relationship

Righteousness practiced apart from relationship doesn't drift—it devours.
It wears the language of obedience while quietly divorcing itself from the heart of God.

Look at **Saul**.

He kept forms but forfeited fear. He sacrificed when he was told to wait. He spared what God said to destroy. He spoke the vocabulary of obedience—*"I have performed the commandment of the Lord"*—while rebellion sat crowned in his chest (1 Samuel 15). Saul didn't fall because he stopped believing; he fell because he stopped listening. Relationship was replaced with ritual, and fear of the people replaced fear of God. The kingdom was lost long before the crown was.

Then come **the sins of Jeroboam**—not one act, but a system.

Golden calves dressed up as convenience. Worship rebranded as accessibility. *"This is too far for you,"* he said—so he lowered God instead of lifting the people. Jeroboam institutionalized righteousness without intimacy, policy without presence. Scripture does not merely record his failure; it memorializes it. His name becomes a measuring rod for generational collapse. One man's relational breach became a nation's inherited blindness.

And then there is **Absalom**—the slow burn.

Years of positioning. Years of listening at the gate. Years of saying the right things while nurturing the wrong heart. He stole affection before he ever reached for authority. Absalom didn't attack the throne with force—he drained it with charm. He knew the language of justice but not the weight of covenant. The end was not merely rebellion; it was devastation—families

torn, loyalties shattered, blood on the ground, and a father weeping over a son who never learned how to submit before trying to rule.

This is the warning Scripture circles like a prophet's fire:

When righteousness is practiced without relationship, it becomes rebellion wearing robes.
It convinces men they are right while God is distant.
It builds structures God never inhabits.
It creates leaders who quote heaven but cannot hear it.

And the cost?

Men lose discernment.
Nations lose covering.
Generations inherit confusion they never chose.

Conquering Leviathan does not begin with a monster in the deep—it begins with a fracture in the heart. Leviathan does not require open sin to rule. He thrives wherever obedience replaces intimacy and authority outruns submission.

The most dangerous rebellion in Scripture is not loud defiance—but quiet distance from God disguised as devotion.

Foreword Reflection

To the Faithful Who Are Tired

There are people who will recognize themselves in this story immediately.

They are not rebels. They are not careless. They are not faithless. They are faithful—and exhausted.

They have prayed when prayer felt empty. They have obeyed when obedience felt costly. They have stood firm when clarity disappeared. They have done everything right, and still sensed that something essential was missing.

If that is you, this story is not written to accuse you.

It is written to invite you to consider.

Many of us were taught how to obey long before we were taught how to abide. We learned discipline before dependence. We learned how to stand before we learned how to lean. And somewhere along the way, faith—meant to be lived in relationship—became something we carried alone.

Fear-based faith teaches us to control, to guard, and to manage righteousness carefully, as though loss were the greatest threat. In the end, obedience severed from faith does not protect righteousness—it replaces God with self-rule.

When obedience is rooted in faith, it becomes life-giving.

When obedience replaces faith, it becomes sin.

Grace-based faith teaches us something far more difficult: to trust that God supplies what we cannot produce—faith itself,

guidance, confidence, knowledge, and the fruit that grows only by abiding.

The battle this book calls *Leviathan* is not fought once. It is fought daily, quietly, in the heart of every sincere believer. It is the battle between fear and grace, law and life, survival and trust.

This story will not rush you to answers.
It will not offer quick comfort.
It will ask you to read slowly, honestly, and with courage.

If you find yourself unsettled, let it be so. If you feel exposed, you are not alone. If you recognize yourself in these pages, you have not failed—you have arrived at the place where grace can finally become your source.

You do not need to build faith. You do not need to guard righteousness. You do not need to carry what God alone must supply. The river is still flowing. You are invited not to manage it, but to enter it.

If this story unsettles you, it is doing its work. If it comforts you too quickly, read more slowly. Faith was never meant to stand alone, nor was obedience meant to lead. When faith becomes the source and obedience the expression, something whole is formed—neither fearful nor fragile, but alive. This is the faith James spoke of: faith working with works, and by those works faith made complete.

ACT I — THE MAN WHO WAS RIGHT

The land prospered under Elior's hand. That was not boast, nor wishful thinking, but fact borne out season after season in quiet, measurable ways: the soil held moisture when it should and released it when it must; the fields rose in straight, deliberate rows, the result of patience rather than force; fences stood true, gates swung cleanly, barns held their lines against wind and weather. Nothing grew wildly and nothing was starved. The land was not hurried; it was stewarded.

Those who passed by noticed, and the noticing had become so ordinary that Elior seldom heard it as praise anymore. Men commented on the neatness of his boundaries, the calm health of his livestock, the way his pastures stayed green longer than theirs even when the heat grew hard. Women remarked—more quietly—on the cleanliness of the yard, the steadiness of the children, the way Mara moved through the day as though the day belonged to her and not the other way around. Elior listened politely when words drifted in his direction, neither deflecting admiration nor receiving it too eagerly. He knew better than to take credit for things that required timing beyond human control. Still, he understood his part. The land did not flourish by accident.

He rose early most mornings, before the sun reached high enough to cast long shadows across the fields. Morning belonged to work best done without noise. The animals were calmer then, the ground cooler, the mind less crowded. He walked the perimeter out of habit, boots finding familiar grooves in the earth without conscious effort, checking gates and hinges, scanning fence lines for strain, pausing to press soil between his fingers as though the earth might speak if handled with care. Order mattered—not because disorder frightened him, but because order produced peace. When things were in their proper place, nothing demanded attention beyond its due measure. The farm moved according to seasons, and seasons

followed rules older than memory. Elior trusted those rules. He trusted God's rules the same way.

Faith, to Elior, had always felt like alignment—life lived in agreement with what had been revealed. God had spoken clearly enough. Obedience was not mystery; it was response. He had learned early that most confusion came not from God's silence, but from man's reluctance to listen. And so Elior listened. He prayed each morning before the day fully claimed him, not with urgency but with intention. His prayers were structured, not rigid, shaped by years of repetition. Gratitude came first. Acknowledgment of God's authority followed. Requests, when made, were modest and measured. He did not bargain. He did not demand. He trusted that alignment would produce fruit, as it always had.

Behind him, the house stirred as the morning progressed. One child burst out the door before Mara could catch him, feet bare against the dirt, hair uncombed, eyes already scanning the world for possibility. The boy moved like a spark—fast, bright, convinced the day existed to be conquered. Another followed more cautiously, pausing at the threshold to pull on boots, mimicking Elior's careful movements with exaggerated seriousness, as if being thorough were the highest form of virtue. "Not past the fence," Mara called gently, not looking up from the table where she worked dough with practiced hands. "Yes, Mama," came the distracted reply, already running. Elior turned, watching them for a moment longer than necessary.

Children moved through the land without understanding its boundaries in the way he did, yet they obeyed them instinctively. They trusted the rules because they trusted the one who made them. They did not ask why the fence stood where it did. They accepted that it marked safety. That trust pleased him, not only because it made his work easier, but because it revealed something fundamental he valued: order that did not need constant enforcement because it had been received.

Family life moved with a rhythm as steady as the seasons. Meals were shared without rush when possible, conversation overlapping and unfinished. Laughter came easily, arguments briefly and without lasting harm. Elior listened more than he spoke, content to let the house fill itself with sound, content to be the quiet wall the noise leaned on. Mara moved through the day with quiet competence, managing the household with the same steadiness Elior brought to the land. She noticed details others missed—small shifts in the children's moods, subtle changes in routine, the particular way the older child's eyes would narrow when he felt corrected, the particular way the younger child's hands clenched when he was afraid. She did not often comment on these things, but Elior had learned to pay attention when she did. Her observations were rarely careless, and never wasted.

There were rhythms within rhythms that defined their prosperity more than numbers ever could. On certain evenings, when the work had gone well and the heat had relented, the children would sit on the porch steps with their legs swinging, and Mara would bring out something sweet—honey bread, or fruit preserved from an earlier harvest—and the family would eat slowly as if to honor the day by refusing to hurry past it. Elior watched the children's faces in those moments, their mouths sticky with sweetness, their eyes bright with stories that felt enormous to them, and he felt the quiet satisfaction of a man whose labor had become shelter. Not perfection—he did not romanticize his life—but goodness that was real, goodness that held.

The farm had become a place others looked to for guidance. When neighboring fields struggled, their owners came to Elior asking about timing, soil, methods, seed. He answered carefully, aware that knowledge given too freely could be misunderstood. He knew how easily men mistook technique for wisdom, and how quickly wisdom became a weapon in the hands of pride. The land taught patience best, and he believed God worked the

same way. There was no need to hurry what seasons would teach.

Elior did not think of himself as righteous in the sense of superiority. Righteousness, as he understood it, was simply life lived correctly. He had learned the instructions and followed them faithfully. That faithfulness had been tested before—lean years, failed harvests, the fever that once swept through a portion of the livestock, the winter when stores ran low and he had learned how quickly pride could turn a man stingy. Each time, obedience had carried him through. He had come to trust it. That trust was quiet and deep. It did not announce itself with drama. It expressed itself in consistency.

He carried a particular habit into his fatherhood with more seriousness than most men would have found necessary. On days when the children were especially loud, especially careless, especially inclined toward mischief—as children naturally were—Elior would grow quiet afterward, watching them at a distance, not as one suspicious but as one attentive. He knew how quickly a heart could be influenced. He knew how easily words spoken in play could become habits spoken in earnest. When they feasted with friends on special days, running wild through the yard and returning home with stories and scraped knees, Elior would wait until the night had settled and the house had grown quiet, then he would kneel by the bed where Mara had already fallen asleep, and pray for them with the seriousness of a man who understood that blessing required care. It was not fear that drove him, but responsibility. He would ask that no unseen fault take root, that no bitterness be planted, that no false confidence grow where humility should have grown. He prayed not because he believed the children were wicked, but because he believed the world was. A father, he thought, was not only one who provided food and shelter, but one who guarded the invisible places.

Mara knew this about him and did not mock it. She had married him partly because of it. She preferred a man who took

unseen things seriously. Yet even Mara, with her quiet strength, sometimes teased him lightly when she found him kneeling after the children were asleep. “They are just children,” she would say, not to correct him but to soften him. Elior would smile and answer, “They are just children, and that is why I pray.” The words were gentle, but the conviction beneath them was immovable.

God had been good. Elior had been faithful. The two had always seemed connected.

Spring came and the farm shifted with it, the ground softening, the air thickening, the animals restless with the change. Planting demanded long days and careful timing. There was always the temptation to hurry the work, to place seed into soil too soon because the sun appeared warm enough, because the mind wanted certainty. Elior resisted that temptation. He trusted patterns he had learned through years of watching the land teach patience with ruthless honesty. He waited. When the time came, he planted with care, the rows straight, the spacing deliberate, the work performed without show.

The children helped in small ways that felt large to them. The younger one carried water in a bucket too big for his frame, sloshing half of it onto his boots, smiling proudly as if he had been entrusted with the whole harvest. The older one insisted on doing tasks he was not yet strong enough to do properly, and Elior corrected him with firmness that held no shame. “Again,” he would say simply. The boy would try again, jaw clenched, pride flickering, then relent into learning. Elior watched him and saw himself. He did not say it aloud. He did not need to. Farms were full of mirrors if a man had eyes to see them.

The fields responded as they always had. Shoots emerged, green and stubborn. The land gave evidence that it had received what was planted. Elior felt the familiar satisfaction of order confirmed. This was how it worked. Discipline produced fruit.

Patience protected what haste would ruin. Rules mattered because they reflected reality.

It was in that season—when life was most ordered, when the land had responded, when the house felt warm with routine—that the first disruption arrived.

It did not announce itself as disaster. It arrived as inconvenience. A delivery that should have come on time did not. Supplies were delayed without explanation. Elior stood at the edge of the fields longer than usual that morning, eyes narrowed slightly as he recalculated what could be done and what would need to wait. Waiting did not trouble him. Waiting had always been part of stewardship. He adjusted his plans without irritation, shifting labor to another task, confident that patience would restore order. He did not speak of it at the table that evening. There was no reason to. Nothing had been lost—only postponed.

Still, the delay lingered in his thoughts longer than it should have. The land had always moved predictably. When disruptions occurred, they carried a cause Elior could identify. This one did not. That alone unsettled him, though he did not yet call it that.

The second disruption followed soon after. A section of fencing failed unexpectedly. Not from neglect, not from storm or strain, but from a weakness Elior had not anticipated. He repaired it himself, hands steady, movements precise, though he could not shake the quiet irritation that accompanied the work. He had inspected that fence recently. He was certain of it. The certainty mattered. It was the sort of certainty he built his life on.

The third disruption came in the form of animals falling ill. Not many—just enough to demand attention. Not enough to alarm the community. Elior worked through the night to tend them, his hands sure, his knowledge sound. He did everything

correctly. The animals recovered slowly, but not without cost: time, effort, resources, all spent where they should not have been needed. When Mara asked if something was wrong, Elior shook his head. “Just a run of things,” he said. She studied him briefly, then nodded. They had lived long enough together to recognize when words were meant to close conversation rather than open it.

The disruptions continued. They did not arrive dramatically. They did not arrive with finality. They came as erosion—small, persistent, cumulative. A crop underperformed despite careful preparation. Equipment failed sooner than expected. A familiar path suddenly closed. Elior responded as he always had: tightening routines, refining discipline, praying with the same words, the same posture, the same trust. God was sovereign. These things passed—except they didn’t.

The farm still produced. The family still laughed. Life still moved forward. And yet something beneath it all felt misaligned, like a wheel slightly off its axis. Elior did not panic. He did not complain. He did not accuse God. Instead, he examined himself. He checked his obedience first. That was instinct. Had he neglected anything? Overlooked a command? Grown careless in discipline? He found nothing obvious. His life remained aligned, his habits unchanged, his prayers faithful. That should have reassured him. Instead, it left him unsettled. Because if obedience was intact, then what was being addressed?

He began to notice how often he returned to the same internal ledger. *I have been careful. I have been faithful. I have done what is required.* He did not speak these thoughts aloud. He would have been ashamed to. Yet the thoughts lived in him quietly, shaping his posture the way unseen roots shape a tree’s direction. He had never thought of himself as a man who needed proof, but he realized—slowly—that he had come to depend on predictable outcomes as confirmation that he was aligned.

One evening, as the family sat together at the table, Elior found himself watching rather than participating. The children argued over something inconsequential, their voices rising and falling without concern. Mara intervened gently, restoring peace with practiced ease. Elior smiled faintly and felt a distance he could not name. “Papa,” one of the children said suddenly, “you’re quiet.” It wasn’t a question. Children noticed things adults explained away. “I was thinking,” he said. “About the farm?” the child asked. “Yes,” Elior replied. The child nodded, satisfied, and returned to eating. Mara glanced at Elior briefly, her eyes lingering just long enough to signal awareness. She did not speak.

Later that night, after the house had gone quiet, Elior returned to the fields. He walked slowly, hands clasped behind his back, eyes scanning ground that had always felt familiar. The moon cast pale light across the rows, revealing order where disorder had been expected. The land was not failing. He was—or rather, something he trusted was.

He knelt there, the earth cool beneath his hands, and prayed. The words came easily. They always did—gratitude, submission, trust. But when he finished, something was missing. Not peace. Not comfort. Expectation. He waited longer than usual. Nothing came. Elior rose slowly. He did not feel abandoned. He felt unanswered, and the distinction unsettled him.

He had always believed that faithfulness produced clarity, if not immediately then eventually. Now clarity seemed withheld, not as punishment but as question. The unasked question pressed closer, felt rather than heard: *Does he trust God—or does he trust the order that obedience produces?* And for the first time, the success of the farm, the health of his family, the correctness of his life felt less like proof and more like something being measured.

He stood in the fields until the night deepened and the cold crept into his bones, and he understood—without knowing how he understood—that the season ahead would not be about crops or fences or deliveries. It would be about what sat underneath his righteousness, what fueled his discipline, what he had been leaning on while believing he was leaning on God.

The breaking had not begun. But the testing had.

And somewhere deep in the quiet, another question waited—one he was not ready for, but could not escape: *If God removes what you rely on, will you still call it faith?*

This fracture—this quiet distance from God disguised as devotion—is the native soil of Leviathan.

Leviathan does not announce himself with scandal. He does not need open rebellion to rule. He coils where reverence has been replaced with routine, where obedience survives but intimacy has died. His power is not first in deception, but in **separation**—separating leaders from listening, authority from submission, righteousness from relationship.

Leviathan feeds on religious confidence without relational fear. He thrives where men still speak God's name but no longer tremble at His voice. He is content to let leaders build altars, systems, and kingdoms—as long as heaven is no longer consulted.

This is why Saul could prophesy and still be rejected.
Why Jeroboam could stabilize a nation and still damn generations.
Why Absalom could speak justice and still shatter covenant.

Leviathan's victory is not moral collapse—it is **relational distance**.
Not lawlessness, but loveless obedience.

Not rebellion shouted, but silence where communion once lived.

And until this fracture is healed, no amount of righteousness will save a man from being devoured by the very thing he believes he is mastering.

End of sample

Thank you for reading the opening of Conquering Leviathan.

The full edition is being prepared for publication.

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